at Hotel Madras International and struck a deal with Zuheira, a Sri Lankan woman who acted as a conduit. Mariam and Fauziyya were funded by a Maldivian banker.

On 24 September 1994, money changed hands at Hotel Luciya, Trivandrum. Nambi Narayanan's son Sankara Kumar received the money and handed it over to Sasikumaran at his house. This money was meant for floating a company to produce bullet-proof materials for export by Srivastava. Thomas Kurisinkal, an industrialist based out of Cochin, was financing the operations. Aleksey Vasin, an officer of the Russian space agency Glavskosmos was involved in the transfer of technology. The plan was to use the drawings and produce Viking engine in North Korea with the help of Russian scientists. A company, a joint venture, was to be floated by Pakistan and Germany. These rockets were to be taken to Pakistan. Indonesia and Brazil were also involved in the deal.

When they summarised the story, I was not sure if I had to laugh or cry. Probably sensing that I was silently ridiculing the lack of logic in their concocted tale, the senior officer became blunt.

'Mr Nambi, we know nothing of this sort happened, but we want this story corroborated by you. All you have to do is mention the name of a Muslim friend.'

The cycle continued, with me naming Abdul Kalam and then Abubaker, my childhood friend who years later had come to me for help to get a job for his son in ISRO. I had told him that I would try if he qualified the written test. The boy did not.

All the while I was on my foot, refusing to take a chair, food or water. The two principal tormentors left and another man, who I reckoned as a Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW) officer, came in.

'You need not lie, just tell what you know. Also remember that we (R&AW and IB) submit different, independent reports to the higher ups. So be bold and tell the truth.'

I told him I have so far said nothing but the truth. After he left, however, I felt reassured. Also, sad that my organisation, ISRO, had not officially